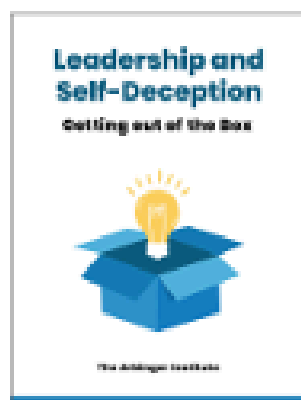




LEADERSHIP AND SELF-DECEPTION

Getting Out of the Box

THE ARBINGER INSTITUTE



The Big “So What”

Self-deception can blind us to real causes behind problems – not only does it erode our effectiveness in work and life, it can spread like a virus to infect everyone around us. This book explains the profound concept of **self-deception**, **how we get stuck in it**, and **how to free ourselves to see new possibilities and solutions**.



Introduction

This book is written as a parable, set in the Zagrum Company. The key characters are:

- Lou Herbert: The former President and CEO of Zagrum;
- Kate Stenarude: The current President and CEO of Zagrum;
- Bud Jefferson: Executive Vice President (EVP) of Zagrum; and
- Tom Callum, one of Zagrum's new senior managers/ division heads.

The parable starts with Tom being invited for a day-long, one-on-one “self-deception meeting” with his new boss, Bud. Such meetings are a tradition at Zagrum – they’re such a crucial part of Zagrum’s success that the top management invests personal time to inculcate the ideas in *every* senior management staff who joins Zagrum. Even Kate, the President and CEO, also attends the sessions personally whenever she can.

The fable takes us through Tom’s discovery process and “aha” moments, as he realizes that he has been “in the box”, and sees how it has affected his relationships and results at work and at home. **In this summary, we’ll present the key ideas in 3 parts – what is “the box”, how we get in, and how to get out.**

KEY QUOTES

“Self-deception is so pervasive that it touches every aspect of life... Self-deception actually determines ones experience in every aspect of life.”

“We hope that this (book) will give people new leverage in their professional and personal lives – leverage to see themselves and others differently, and therefore leverage to solve what has resisted solution and to improve what can yet be improved.”

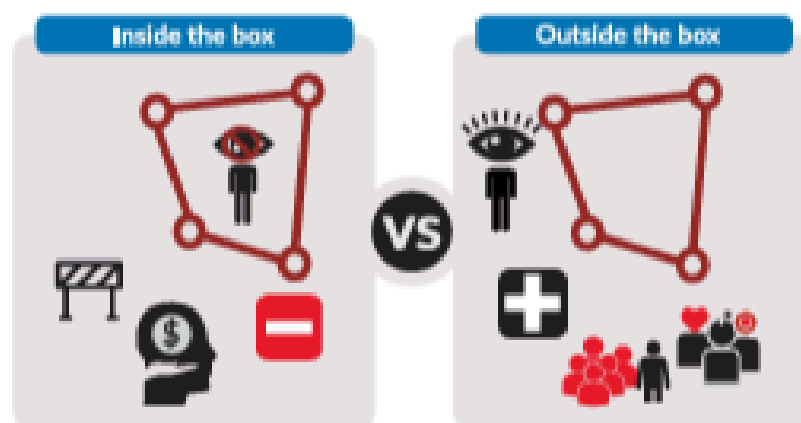
“Of all the problems in organizations, self-deception is the most common, and the most damaging.”



What is "The Box"?

Self-deception is a problem encountered by every human being. It's like being stuck in a box - despite our best intentions, we have a biased view of problems, and are blind to their underlying causes and our roles in them. Since we cannot see (or resist the possibility) that we are the problem, everything we do while we're in the box tends to be counter-productive. It hinders our ability to make effective decisions, and erodes our leadership abilities and happiness levels. Once the box is removed, or when we get outside the box, new possibilities and solutions emerge.

Being in versus out of the box



People vs objects. When we are in the box, we view and treat others as objects e.g. a vehicle to help us accomplish our goals, or a problem, threat, or obstacle to what we want. We are the priority, and our needs/ wants are much more important than theirs. When we are out of the box, we view and treat others as people, with equally important wants, hopes and dreams.

Imagine you're rushing for an important meeting. As the lift-doors close, you see someone running frantically toward it. In that split second, you decide to let the doors close, so you won't be delayed further. You're acting from inside the box - the other person is like an object, an obstacle to your meeting, and his needs are less legitimate than yours at that point.



It's more than your behaviour. Being outside the box is much deeper than just changing your outward behaviour.

- o People are intuitive and can sense your true intentions. The same action, when done from inside vs outside the box, can create markedly different outcomes. For instance, you forget to pick up the groceries which you'd promised to do.

KEY QUOTES

"Self-deception... blinds us to the true causes of problems, and once we're blind, all the 'solutions' we can think of will actually make matters worse."

"Given a little time, we can always tell when we're being coped with, manipulated, or outsmarted. We can always detect the hypocrisy."

Your wife is very upset, so you apologize to pacify her. However, you're silently thinking how unreasonable she's being, given your long day at work and all you've done for her (i.e. you're acting from inside the box). In this case, your apology is unlikely to be well-received.

- o The defining factor is whether you are doing what the other person needs, or what you need, whether you're really interested in the other person, or merely that person's opinion of you. When you are focusing on the other person's needs, even if you're harsh on the person, it'll still be better received than if you take a soft approach just to manipulate him to do what you want.

 As a rule of thumb, if you're not even interested in someone's name, it's a clear sign that you're not interested in him/ her as a person. However, simply knowing a person's name doesn't mean you see him/ her as a person.

Finding the Problem beneath the Problem



Bud shares a true event from the 1800s. Ignaz Semmelweis was an obstetrician in Vienna, who was perplexed by the alarmingly high mortality rate of women in his maternity wards - 1 out of 10 women were dying from "childbed fever". While the doctors could identify the symptoms, they couldn't find a remedy that worked, and patients continued to die rapidly at the hospital.

Finally, by chance, they discovered that the cause of the deaths were the doctors themselves. It turned out that most of the doctors, especially Semmelweis, had been working on corpses, and were unknowingly passing germs to the patients via contact. This was before the discovery of the germ-theory, and the doctors' efforts to treat the fever were ironically backfiring as they were the very cause of the disease! Once they instituted the practice of washing their hands in chorine-and-lime solution, the mortality rate fell to 1 in 100.

Self-deception, like childbed fever, is merely a symptom. If left untreated, it can cause severe damage. Yet, treating it requires that we find the germ that causes it in the first place. We'll now take a closer look at the box, how we get in, and how to get out.

KEY QUOTES

"No matter what skill you teach me, I can be either in the box or out of the box when I implement it."

"People primarily respond not to what we do but to how we're being - whether we're in or out of the box toward them."



How We Get In the Box

Self Betrayal



As human beings, we intuitively know what we should do for others. When we're out of the box, we see what we can do, and we often want to do things for others (e.g. holding the door for someone, apologizing for a mistake, sharing a useful piece of information).

Yet, **we often don't do what we know we should**, i.e. we betray ourselves. Once we betray ourselves, we start to create justifications for our lack of action, which skews how we see the world.

Imagine you failed to complete a project on time. You know you should take responsibility, but instead, came up with a white lie about being very ill that week. You've just betrayed yourself. Soon, you start to notice how Susan had a mistake in her submission, and Tom missed out an important reference. You feel better, thinking how sloppily they've rushed through their work, unlike all of the previous times when you completed your projects perfectly. Before long, you find yourself thinking, "No wonder I couldn't complete my work – all these slackers are just putting up half-baked stuff and I'm the only one taking it seriously!"

This simple example shows how **the justifications for our own self-betrayal can lead to self-deception**. It happens in all aspects of work and personal life, and is typically characterized by 4 things:

👹 We exaggerate others' fault;

😬 We exaggerate our own virtue;

🔍 We magnify the value of things that justify our self-betrayal; and

👉 We blame others for making us feel/ act the way we do.



How We Get In the Box

KEY QUOTES

"An act contrary to what I feel I should do for another is called an act of 'self-betrayal'."

"Self-betrayal is the germ that creates the disease of self-deception."

"The box is a metaphor for how I'm resisting others... I'm actively resisting what the humanity of others calls me to do for them."

Typically, there is a marked difference in how we view others before versus after our self-betrayal. In the example above, you didn't think so poorly of your colleagues and their work until after your own betrayal.

Living in the Box



With time, some boxes may become so innate to us that we carry them with us. We no longer need the sense of betrayal to get in the box, because we're *already* in the box. We constantly see ourselves, others, and circumstances through these self-justifying lenses, and even bring our biases into new situations.

- For example, if you have a self-justifying image that you're a great husband, and your wife complains that you don't give her enough attention, you're likely to feel that she's being ungrateful, without really considering her point. Or, if you have a self-justifying image that you're the expert in your field, you may dismiss others' inputs, and they stop sharing suggestions with you over time.
- Thus, if you find yourself in the box, with no sense of self-betrayal, consider if you're carrying self-justifying views about others. When you can finally see how biased your views have been, you're likely to feel a shift and no longer feel the need to "win".

Collusion



When we're in the box, we want to feel justified. We focus on finding ways to reinforce how wrong or bad the other person is, and end up losing sight of our real goals. For example, you're upset with a staff and deliberately set him a tough goal to prove that he's incompetent. When he unexpectedly delivers, you're frustrated to be proven wrong, even though this is should've been a positive work outcome. Instead of appreciating his work, you end up being unreasonably critical.



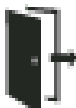
When we're in the box, we tend to blame others. It puts them on the defensive, and incites them to get in their boxes. They start blaming us, we blame them for blaming us, and the vicious cycle continues; we're basically colluding to stay in our respective boxes.

KEY QUOTES

"By being in the box, I provoke others to be in the box."

Being "in the box" limits our ability to deliver results and reach our full potential. Our views are biased, and we're so busy trying to prove things to ourselves that our results are compromised. No amount of skills and techniques will help when our focus is fundamentally wrong.

In short, when we are in the box, all of these don't work:

-  Attempting to change others. Even if others should change or improve, it does not give us an excuse to be in the box. These are 2 independent factors. Attempting to change someone when we are in the box will only backfire and prompt them to get in their boxes.
-  Tolerating or bearing with others. Trying to tolerate or cope with others implies that we still carry our self-justified views and are still blaming others.
-  Leaving. Walking away may be the right move in some situations, but it doesn't solve the underlying problem, as we're simply bringing our boxes with us.
-  Communicating. No matter how skilled you are, so long as you are in the box, you're blaming others and seeking self-justification. The other party will sense it, and respond accordingly.
-  Using skills or techniques. Skills or technique are valuable, but ineffective when they're applied from inside the box.
-  Modifying your behaviour. As discussed earlier, changing your outward behaviour doesn't work, as you're still inwardly focusing on yourself, and the gesture will feel insincere.

So long as we're in the box, all our actions are counter-productive. Still, it's inevitable that we'll slip into the box occasionally. The key is to become aware of it, and to embrace it as an improvement tool for yourself and the whole organization.

Self-Deception and Organizational Results



Most of us start a job with excitement, gratitude, anticipation and the intention to do our best for the organization and our colleagues. However, over time, self-betrayal and deception sets in, and our feelings change.

KEY QUOTES

"People problems seem intractable not because they are insoluble but because the common skill interventions are not themselves solutions."

"From within the box I end up undermining the effectiveness of everything I do."

Self-deception can be one of the biggest hindrances to organizational results, with symptoms like a lack of commitment, trust and accountability, conflict, stress, poor teamwork, and communication issues.



As seen earlier, when someone is in the box, it triggers others to also get in the box, and this spreads like a disease throughout the organization.



People in the box are focused on self-justifications, which often clash with what's best for the organization. Instead of focusing on improvements and personal accountability, time and energy is wasted on justifications and blaming others.



Being Outside the Box

When we're in the box, we resist others and what they need from us. When we're out of the box, we see people for who they are, including their hopes, fears, dreams, and gifts; we recognize their needs.

On the surface, it'd seem as if living outside the box brings additional burden. However, in reality, the reverse holds true:

- Acting from outside the box doesn't mean we have to give in to everyone's whims and fancies. We can still prioritize what's important to us, yet treat others with genuine courtesy, respect and consideration, bringing more positive responses and results.
- When we're out of the box, we see people as they are, without prejudices and judgements. We're liberated from trying to justify and prove things to ourselves.

Getting Out of the Box



At any point in time, we are in-the-box toward some people and out-of-the-box toward others. Our out-of-the-box relationships provide a space or opening for us to see our in-the-box relationships in new light. When we start to question our magnified virtues and self-justifying views, our biases toward others will also start to dissolve. As we see others as people again, we'll start to feel like doing our part, or righting past wrongs - we're out of the box.

KEY QUOTES

"In the box we provoke others to get in the box - both with and against us."

"We live insecurely when we're in the box, desperate to show that we're justified."

"The more we can find our way to the 'out-of-the-box' vantage points within us, the more readily we will be able to shine light on the in-the-box justifications we are carrying."

Once we're out of the box, the biggest challenge is to stay out of the box. The only way to achieve that is to apply what we've learnt so far, using these tips:

- Focus on improvements, not perfection. If you find yourself in the box, apologize and move on.
- Use the principles yourself, rather than preach to those who're new to the concept.
- Focus on staying out of your box, not focus on others' boxes.
- Focus on what you can do for others, not what they're doing wrong, or what they're not doing for you.

Leadership inside vs outside the Box



In the parable, Tom learns how Zagrum was transformed using the principles he'd just learnt. Lou Herbert, the former President and CEO, had such a strong self-justifying image of his own brilliance and expertise that he unknowingly stifled creativity and trust in the organization. Since he was in his box, he failed to see that people were feeling apathetic or rebellious because of him; instead, he blamed others for their behaviours and became even more controlling and instructive. The same pattern occurred at home with his wife and son. Over time, good people started to leave Zagrum, and his family was falling apart.

Fortunately, Lou learned about self-deception and the box just in time. By stepping out of his box, he was able to convince Kate to return to work for him and transform Zagrum together. He also successfully mended his relationships with his wife and son.

As a leader, when you lead from inside the box, people may still follow you out of obligation. However, when you lead from outside the box, people choose to follow you. **When you operate out-of-the-box, you can recognize others' boxes without blaming them for being in it, and you're free from self-betrayal. This encourages similar behaviours in others, develops new leaders and creates a virtuous cycle of trust.**

Imagine that you're being considered for a promotion, after many years of hard work, and you discover that one of your new staff has made a crucial mistake that can derail an entire project.

KEY QUOTES

"Merely knowing the material doesn't get you out of the box. Living it does."

"It isn't about perfection... It's simply about getting better."

"The solution to the self-betrayal problem is the solution to all... people problems."

"Your success as a leader... depends on being free of self-betrayal.... Only then do you invite others to be free of self-betrayal."

"We won't know who we work and live with... until we leave the box and join them."

- If you act from *inside* the box, you'd put the blame on the staff to protect yourself. Even if it *seems* justified, the staff will learn to "watch his own back" in future, and you'd both be working for yourselves, from inside your respective boxes.
- If you act from *outside* the box, you'd probably recognize that you could've guided your staff more closely, and hence take full responsibility as his supervisor. Even if you were to speak firmly with your staff after that, he'll respect you and want to do better in future.

Applying the Concepts



The principles in this book can be applied to all aspects of your work and personal life. Based on real-life feedback from readers, Arbinger has identified 5 useful areas of application:



Hiring: You can use the book as required reading material for potential hires, then evaluate the candidates through post-reading discussions.



Leadership & team-building: Share the book and its ideas with your leaders and team-members, to create awareness of in-the-box and out-of-the-box behaviours, and improve teamwork, interaction and results.



Conflict resolution. The ideas in this book are useful for mediation, handling conflict or volatile situations, especially when combined with the Peacemaking Pyramid from the book "The Anatomy of Peace". Conflict resolution becomes possible just by opening up people's minds to their own roles in the situation. Acting outside the box and treating the other party as people (rather than enemies or vermin), can also significantly improve outcomes.



Staff transformation. Before firing or removing a staff, try using this book as a rehabilitation tool to help them shift their perspectives.



Personal development. This book can also be used in educational institutions and business courses to build strong foundations for students and business leaders.

KEY QUOTES

"Companies fail for the same reason families do... both are organizations of people."

"The reason this book has been so instrumental in helping people to resolve conflict is that it opens readers to how they have helped to create the very problems they have attributed to others."



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

The book was originally published in 2000, and this second edition (published in 2010) expanded on the original book with updated material and ideas for application. This is an easy-to-read parable, with numerous work and personal examples that are highly-relatable and packed with nuances to reflect the common challenges and scenarios in our work and life.

We've modified the some of the examples in this summary to present the gist of the ideas. Reading the book in itself can provide an out-of-the-box environment for us to examine our relationships and effectiveness. For more references and details, do get a copy of the book, or visit www.arbinger.com.

About The Arbinger Institute

Arbinger provides training, consulting, coaching, and implementation tools that move individuals, teams, and organizations from the inward mindset to the results focus of an outward mindset.



This is built on the knowledge that, without a change in mindset, newly adopted behaviors won't stick and results will suffer. Arbinger is the world leader in transforming mindset, and their programs and methodology are based on 45 years of research in the psychology of human behavior and motivation, and more than 35 years of experience working with organizations worldwide.

KEY QUOTES